

THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Quadrilateral Meeting with Presidents Franjo Tudjman of Croatia, Alija Izetbegovic of Bosnia-Herzegovina, and Slobodan Milosevic of Serbia (U)

PARTICIPANTS: U.S.
The President
Warren Christopher, Secretary of State
Anthony Lake, Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs
Samuel R. Berger, Deputy Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs
Richard Holbrooke, Assistant Secretary of State for European and Canadian Affairs
Alexander Vershbow, Senior Director for European Affairs, NSC Staff (Notetaker)

Franjo Tudjman, President of the Republic of Croatia
Alija Izetbegovic, President of the Republic of Bosnia-Herzegovina
Slobodan Milosevic, President of Serbia

DATE, TIME December 14, 1995, 9:20-9:45 a.m.
AND PLACE: U.S. Ambassador's Residence, Paris, France

The President: Welcome. You have all taken significant risks in getting to today's peace agreement, and there are serious risks still ahead. We are prepared to share those risks, not only in our military involvement, but in doing our part in the reconstruction effort. I would like to hear your views, but first let me make a few points. ~~(C)~~

First, it is important that we stay with this agreement. There can be flexibility in implementation, but we should not change the terms of the Dayton agreement. Genuine freedom of movement needs to be guaranteed as soon as possible. The elections need to be carried out. The removal of all foreign forces is very important. It is important that all of you believe that IFOR is doing the job that you agreed it should do in an evenhanded way. Let me say to each of you personally that I have great personal

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confidence in General Joulwan and Admiral Smith. They are both very good men. But if any of you believes that they are not doing their job in an evenhanded way, let me know directly. The implementation force will make the agreement you created at Dayton a reality. Our troops are trained and ready to do just that. ~~(C)~~

Second, I want to stress how important I regard the letter that you wrote to me expressing your commitment to ensure the safety of U.S. and Allied troops. This letter helped greatly with the American people. Other things that are also important to me and to the American people include: the right of refugees to return; the protection of the human rights of every ethnic group, wherever they live; and the ability of the work of the War Crimes Tribunal to go forward and be respected. I also believe that any step that you can take to symbolize the benefits of peace would be very important. I encourage you to move toward mutual recognition and to consider visiting one another's capitals. Symbolic actions can have a major impact on your own people and the rest of the world. ~~(C)~~

What you have done in reaching this peace agreement is very important; it truly matters to people throughout the world. We will do all we can to make it succeed. You need to work in an open atmosphere in order to increase mutual trust. The United States will be true to its word -- to each and all of you. ~~(C)~~

President Milosevic: The strongest guarantee of success is the fact that all the people are for peace. The Serbs, Muslims and Croats -- or at least a big majority -- all want peace. That is why I'm an optimist. No one can say there won't be any problems. There is a rough road ahead, but there is no doubt in my mind that success is guaranteed. The main key to success is the evenhanded implementation of the agreement. ~~(C)~~

The President: One thing that all of you should think about, in addition to reconstruction, is how to find ways to demonstrate to the people who live in the region and throughout the world that ordinary people want peace. The media don't do that. They paid great attention when people were dying, when ordinary people were suffering. But since you agreed to a ceasefire and to the peace agreement, the only publicity is focused on the points of trouble. You need to find ways to show the world and the people inside Bosnia that the majority of the population wants peace. A big problem that we had with members of Congress is the fact that, from the minute the fighting stopped, they have been focusing only on the bad things. There will always be problems, but we need to do a better job in highlighting the good news. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: You can be sure, Mr. President, that we will do everything necessary for the implementation of the peace agreement. I would like to stress one point that is of great importance: implementation of the settlement in Eastern Slavonia. ~~(C)~~

The President: I agree. I want to discuss that with you. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: The common people in Bosnia want peace. I'm not sure about some groups, however. We expect that President Milosevic will calm those groups. ~~(C)~~

President Milosevic: With your help. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: We will cooperate in this regard. The proof that the people want peace is that the ceasefire has been maintained without any serious incidents, and the small incidents have been very rare. People are tired of war. It is very important that all the parts of the peace agreement be implemented, especially those on human rights and the right of refugees to return. Perhaps the most important provisions of all are those concerning elections. This is a problem for the international community -- for international organizations, the OSCE. Help on elections is as important as your troops, since it is the prerequisite to removing those who created the hatred from power, and thereby creating an opportunity for Bosnia and the region to achieve a better future. Let me assure you that your troops are welcome in Bosnia. I believe they will have no problems. ~~(C)~~

The President: The elections are important not only to eliminating those who may not run for office from political life (as you agreed at Dayton), but to show every ethnic group that they can be represented, that their voices will be heard. I will emphasize the elections when I speak to the conference this morning. We will do all we can to make sure that the agreement you designed can work. One of the missions of IFOR is to create a secure environment so that the elections can be held. We want the IFOR mission to be terminated in an appropriate way. We can't do that unless free elections are a fact. ~~(C)~~

President Milosevic: After the first elections, I'm convinced that we will be able to define the situation as normal. Elections will be a turning point. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: It is important that the elections be held in normal conditions -- that is, terror must have been removed, and most people must have been returned to their homes. Without such conditions, in areas where radical ethnic cleansing occurred and terror now rules, there will not be a possibility of

free and fair elections. So we must first create the conditions for elections before the elections can take place. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: It is also important that all three constituent peoples be equal during and after the elections. This is important for Bosnia's future peace. ~~(C)~~

Secretary Christopher: All three Presidents worked hard to maximize the chances for successful elections, in terms of the allocation of offices and provisions for voting. The main thing is to implement the terms you so carefully worked out in Dayton. Now I suggest that the President meet for a few minutes individually with each leader. ~~(C)~~

The President: Let me make one more comment. The confidence you have expressed in this conversation needs to be communicated to the people on the ground. You can change the psychology of the situation. I was just in Northern Ireland, where they fought each other for 25 years. Now we have had over 15 months without fighting. It is unthinkable for most people that they could go back. With the growth in confidence, the whole situation has changed. In the face of skepticism about the peace in Bosnia, you need to voice confidence in your public statements. ~~(C)~~

-- End of Conversation --

Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

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